From Users to Public Profiles

How the push to "build a digital presence" is quietly reshaping student learning, identity, and long-term opportunity — and what educators need to understand about this shift.

PART 2: THE DIGITAL IDENTITY SHIFT

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A CASE STUDY

Meet Arjun

Arjun is a second-year engineering student encouraged — like many peers — to build a visible digital presence. He created profiles across four major platforms:

1

LinkedIn

Skills and certifications listed

2

GitHub

Lab assignments and code

3

Kaggle

Beginner dataset attempts

4

Quora / Stack Overflow

Occasional answers posted

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The Gap Between Appearance and Reality

From a distance, Arjun looked proactive, capable, and engaged. Up close, the picture was more complicated.

What Recruiters Saw

Confidence. Technical ability. A student who was digitally active and professionally aware.

What Was Actually There

Incomplete or copied GitHub code. LinkedIn skills barely explored. Answers drawn from quick searches — not genuine understanding.

Arjun was not being deliberately dishonest. He was doing what he believed everyone else was doing: **presenting himself in the best possible light in a competitive digital environment.**

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THE CORE PROBLEM

When Visibility Outweighs Competence

Digital platforms do not distinguish between deep expertise and surface-level familiarity. Everything appears equally credible when presented well.

Profiles over Progress

Students prioritise maintaining a polished profile over developing genuine skills.

Curated Realities

Online presence becomes a carefully managed performance, not an honest record of learning.

Learning Becomes Secondary

The incentive to *be seen as skilled* gradually overtakes the drive to *actually become skilled.*

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THE PERMANENT RECORD PROBLEM

Digital Platforms Never Forget

Unlike a classroom test or a semester grade, **digital activity does not disappear.** Arjun's early mistakes — poorly written code, incorrect answers, exaggerated skill claims — remain publicly visible years after they were posted.

A recruiter reviewing his profile years later may not interpret those early posts as signs of growth. They may read them as signs of inconsistency, unreliability, or poor judgement.

The critical tension: Digital platforms reward early participation — but they also permanently record early ignorance.

EARLY PARTICIPATION

Platforms reward:
Post early,
Build visibility,
Engage quickly

PERMANENT RECORD

Early mistakes,
Incomplete work,
Visible forever

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